

New Light on the Karimun Besar Inscription (Prasasti Pasir Panjang) and the Learned Man from Gaur

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There is an inscription of extraordinary significance etched into a granite hill on the northern coast of Karimun Besar, one of the Riau islands located to the southwest of Singapore. The inscription records the visit of a holy man whose identity, up till now, has not been well understood. It is said that the inscription dates to the Sriwijaya era and refers to a person who is “astrolabe-endowed” (*golayantrita*). The claim is often repeated in scholarship on the Prasasti Pasir Panjang, as it is called in Indonesian, and goes back to the first published study (Brandes 1887:150). The “astrolabe” reading confuses three glyphs, as can be seen from recent photographs, and can now be safely retired.

It has further been proposed that the inscription refers to “The holy footprints of The Venerable Gautama [Buddha]” (Caldwell & Hazlewood 1994:475). However, the indentations in the granite do not look much like footprints. It is grammatically more feasible that the inscription contains the proper name Gautamaśrī, as a couple of scholars realised back in the early twentieth century (Kern 1917:142; Chatterjee 1933:95–96). The inscription most likely



FIGURE 2A: THE INSCRIBED STUPA BASE AT GUITAH BAHİ IN PATAN, NEPAL. (CREDIT: ANDREA WOLLEIN)

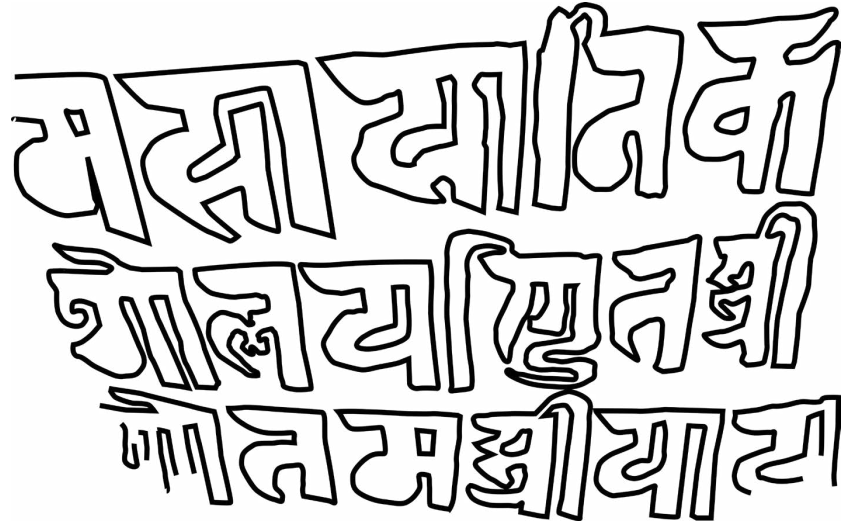


FIGURE 1: THE GLYPHS OF THE KARIMUN INSCRIPTION, A.K.A. PRASASTI PASIR PANJANG. ITS THREE LINES READ AS FOLLOWS: 1: mahāyānika 2: gaulapaṇḍitaśrī 3: gautamaśrīpādā[h]: “the feet of glorious Gautamaśrī, Mahāyānist pundit of Gaur.” MANUALLY TRACED FROM CALDWELL & HAZLEWOOD (1994:462). (CREDIT: IAIN SINCLAIR)

means: “the feet [i.e. the honourable presence] of glorious Gautamaśrī, Mahāyānist pundit of Gaur.” What has not yet been done is to identify the illustrious pundit who journeyed to Riau from Gaur in Bengal.

Who was Gautamaśrī? Many sources from outside Southeast Asia refer to a pundit named Gautamaśrī who was active in the early-mid 13th century. This Gautamaśrī appears to have sought refuge in the Himalayas after the collapse of the Hindu-Buddhist Sena dynasty. The Senas, formerly the rulers of much of Bengal, retreated to Gaur as the Turkish invasions broke up their empire. Gautamaśrī would have joined the exodus of other learned men from Eastern India as they resettled in places such as Nepal and began to teach Tibetan and Newar students. Tibetan lineage documents identify Gautamaśrī as an expert in over a dozen texts and tantric practices, many of which were passed on to the Tibetan Sakyapa

tradition and are still studied today. He also helped to translate Sanskrit texts into Tibetan. According to the colophon of one translation, Gautamaśrī had visited Sakya monastery in Tibet itself (Bühnemann 1994:16).

In 1253 a young lama of the Sakyapas, Dampa Künga Drak (1230–1303), was advised to travel to meet and study with Gautamaśrī. Dampa later performed war magic for the Mongols in their campaign to establish the Yuan dynasty, and rose to join the court of Kublai Khan. The connection between Dampa and Gautamaśrī is recorded in Chinese sources and has so far remained unnoticed, since the Chinese-language transcription of Gautamaśrī’s name (*Gudamashili* 古達麻室利) was not read correctly in the only published study of Dampa’s life (Franke 1994:160 n.14).

Gautamaśrī was also involved with the ancient monastic complex of Guitah in the Kathmandu Valley of Nepal. Guitah,

पञ्चिक

गौतमश्री

FIGURE 2B: THE WORDS *paṇḍita* ...śrīgautamaśrī INSCRIBED IN RED ON THE STUPA BASE. (CREDIT: IAIN SINCLAIR)



FIGURE 3: THE EXTENSION TO GUITAH BAHİ BUILT BY GAUTAMAŚRĪ JULY 8, 2018. (CREDIT: ANDREA WOLLEIN)

*“What could have driven
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which still functions as a monastery for the Newar community, preserves two stone inscriptions that mention Gautamaśrī. One inscription, carved on the pedestal of the standing Buddha image in the main sanctum, is dated in the 339th year of the Nepalese era. This year corresponds to 1279 CE. The pedestal inscription commemorates the rebuilding of the part of the monastery built by Gautamaśrī, which seems to have been destroyed in the catastrophic Nepal earthquake of 1255. The poetic language of the inscription testifies to a certain level of literary accomplishment at Guitah; it calls Gautamaśrī a “god among ascetics,” a *yatīndra*.

Another inscription at Guitah, located on the base of a stupa in the main courtyard, credits Gautamaśrī with having built part of the monastery. The stupa pedestal was inscribed in the year 144 (Vajrācārya 1999:60). If this year is interpreted in the dating system of Gaur – the Lakshman Samvat – it gives a date corresponding to 1250 CE, and as such would have been written in Gautamaśrī’s lifetime. The inscription refers to the *paṇḍita* called *śrīgautamaśrī* – the very same wording as the Karimun inscription. This commonality leaves little doubt that the inscriptions in Nepal and at

Karimun refer to the same person.

What could have driven a Buddhist pundit from Bengal not only to the Himalayas, but as far away as the Singapore Strait? The 13th century was a time of major upheaval, with the Turkish invasions of South Asia clashing with the Mongol expansions into East and Central Asia, causing massive demographic shifts. The sea routes that reopened after the demise of the Senas would have offered a path out of this chaos to the relative peace of Southeast Asia. Gautamaśrī’s presence in the Riau Islands coincides with a final flourishing of Sanskrit culture in Java and Sumatra, as seen in the inscriptions of Singasari and Ādityavarman, which can now be re-examined with reference to Gautamaśrī’s expertise. In conclusion, the inscription at Karimun Besar should now be appreciated as a major milestone on the Maritime Silk Road, and due attention given to its conservation and further study.

IAIN SINCLAIR IS A VISITING FELLOW AT NSC. THIS ARTICLE IS A SHORT PREVIEW OF THE AUTHOR’S WORK IN PROGRESS (SINCLAIR 2018).

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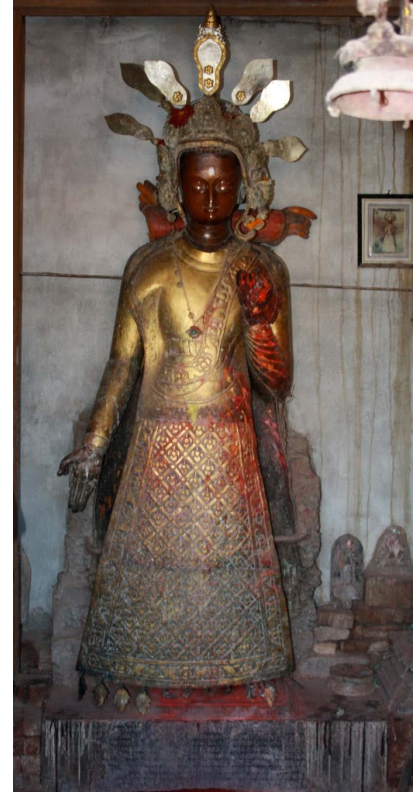


FIGURE 4: THE STANDING BUDDHA OF GUITAH BAHİ AND ITS INSCRIBED PEDESTAL. 2013.. (CREDIT: AURORA GRALDI)

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